

3.3.2 Setting Up The Server

The most preferred servers are still Linux, but only because a Web server running Windows NT or Server 2003 will burn a hole in your pocket, at least initially. Since Linux is the free option (and we'd rather not consider the 'free' Windows option that the local software pirate will hand you), we'll stick with it for now. Of course, you could always decide to purchase Windows Server 2003, or just run the Web server on your existing operating system—Linux/Unix/BSD, Windows XP/2000/Me/98.

Since Windows XP Professional comes with Microsoft's Internet Information Services (IIS), which also has an in-built Web server, you could choose this to run an alternative ASP-based Web site. Of course, you can still choose to use Open Source software such as the popular Apache Web server (www.apache.org) to host your site.

The screenshot shows the Apache Software Foundation homepage. The header includes the logo and the URL <http://www.apache.org/>. The main content area is titled 'Welcome' and contains a paragraph about the foundation's mission to support the open source software community. Below this, there are links for 'Support the Apache Software Foundation' and 'Latest News'. A sidebar on the right contains links for 'Sponsorship', 'How it Works', 'Get Involved', and 'Download'. The footer includes a copyright notice for 2005 and a link to the 'Privacy Policy'.

You need to install a Web server, such as Apache, from www.apache.org, in order to host a site

Since we're looking at the cheapest solutions to minimise the costs you have to incur when starting up a Web site, we will stick to Open Source software and freeware.

If you have decided to use Apache for a PHP/MySQL-based site, the first thing you need to do is download Apache from www.apache.org. Make sure to choose the latest Win32 Binary. You will find a list of Mirror sites to download Apache from at <http://www.apache.org/dyn/closer.cgi>.

Install Apache and configure the `httpd.conf` file located in the `install-root/conf/` folder. Here the default `install-root` is "C:\Program Files\Apache Group\Apache2\"